Knowledge and Reality
Philosophy 26600

Spring 2023
Tu Th 11:30-12:45, Room W413
Office hours: Tu 1:00 – 2:00, Room W1447

Instructor: Boris Ayala
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In this course, we will explore some questions about the nature of reality (What kinds of things are real? Is the mind made of matter? What is time?) and about our knowledge of it (Does knowledge have a structure? What are its limits? How can we be sure we have it?). The first set of questions falls under metaphysics, and the second under epistemology.

Learning Objectives
We will learn how some great minds have thought about these questions. We will also, and importantly, try to improve our thinking and writing skills.

Required Readings
You don't need to buy any textbooks. I will post on Blackboard the required readings. Please print them, read them in advance, and bring them to the relevant class. We will often do close reading in class, and to follow you will need to have the text before you.

Class Philosophy
Since thinking and writing are both skills, we can improve them with practice. Accordingly, this course is set up to encourage continuous practice. We will have many short writing assignments. While each assignment's impact on your final grade will be minor, these assignments as a whole take up the largest share of your final grade. This class thus rewards steady effort. Further, because I really want you to get better at thinking and writing, you will always have an opportunity to rewrite your work for a better grade.

Grade Components

Weekly Arguments	30 points
Participation	15 points
Quizzes	10 points
Paper 1	20 points
Paper 2	25 points
Total	100 points

Grade Scale

97 – 100	A+	78 – 80	B-
92 – 96	A	75 – 77	C+
89 – 91	A-	70 – 74	C
85 – 88	B+	60 – 69	D
81 – 84	B	Less than 60	F

Weekly Arguments
Every Thursday, by 8 p.m., you will email me a short argument that responds to any portion of the reading assigned for Friday. The argument should be about 300 words long and must be submitted as a WORD document (*no* PDFs). I aim to email them back, with a grade and comments, before our Friday class. There will be a total of 13 weekly arguments this semester, but I will count only your best 10 toward your final grade. Please note that weekly arguments are the *biggest component* of your final grade. I suggest you spend at least 2 hours writing each one.

Each argument will be graded from 1 to 3, based on both the quality of the argument and the quality of the writing. You will always have a chance to improve your grade by emailing me *both* the first draft with my comments *and* your rewrite, together, at any point before the following Tuesday class.

Quizzes
Every Tuesday, we will have a quiz at the beginning of class. Each quiz will consist of only a couple of questions, which may be answered with a single word or sentence. There will be 12 quizzes, but only your best 10 will count toward your final grade. Each quiz contributes exactly one point toward your final grade, and if you take all 12 quizzes you will get two additional points toward your final grade.

Participation and Attendance
Everybody will begin the semester with 5 points. You can earn up to 10 more by asking questions or volunteering answers. You may also lose points, for example, if you check your cell phone or chat with other students during class. If you don't participate in class, you will keep the original 5 points.

I will take attendance at the beginning of each class. If you arrive after I take attendance, you will be considered absent. You may still earn participation points, however, on days you arrive late. The first three unexcused instances of lateness or absence are free. After that, I will take off one participation point per absence/lateness. However, if you reach 10 late or absent days in a semester, you will have failed this course.

Papers
You will write two 5-page papers for this class, due on the dates listed below. Each paper must develop one of the weekly arguments in which you got 3 points. If none of your arguments got 3 points, please talk to me *in advance* so we can agree on a way forward. After I return your papers, you will have 2 weeks to hand in an improved version for a better grade.

Electronics Policy
The use of any electronics in class is prohibited.

Academic Integrity
Any instances of cheating will result in your failing this course. The CUNY Policy on Academic Integrity applies to this course, and further consequences may follow.

Schedule for the Semester

1		Jan 27 Introduction
2	Jan 31 Appearance and Reality	Feb 3 Existence of Matter
3	Feb 7 Nature of Matter	Feb 10 Idealism
4	Feb 14 Acquaintance Knowledge	Feb 17 Induction
5	Feb 21 [Monday Schedule]	Feb 24 Truth and Justification
6	Feb 28 Defining Knowledge	Mar 3 Justified True Belief
7	Mar 7 Foundationalism	Mar 10 Coherentism
8	Mar 14 **Paper 1 Due**	Mar 17 Ontology
9	Mar 21 Ontology cont'd	Mar 24 Abstract Entities
10	Mar 28 Abstract Entities cont'd	Mar 31 Material Objects
11	Apr 4 Material Objects cont'd	Apr 7 Spring Break
12	Apr 11 Spring Break	Apr 14 Critiques of Metaphysics
13	Apr 18 Time	Apr 21 Epistemic Injustice
14	Apr 25 Belief Adoption	Apr 28 Anti-Realism
15	May 2 Propositions / **Paper 2 Due**	May 5 Metaphysics of Race
16	May 9 Misinformation	